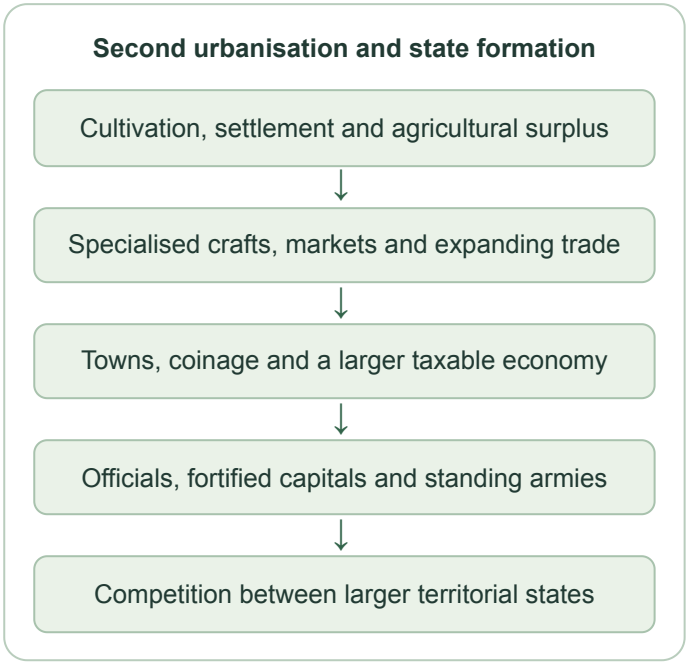
The Mahajanapadas of the Indo-Gangetic Plain

1. Why the sixth century BCE matters

- **c.600–300 BCE**: larger territorial states, expanding towns, monetised exchange and new religious movements. **Second urbanisation** follows the Harappan urban phase after a long interval; its major focus is the **Ganga basin**, especially eastern Uttar Pradesh and Bihar. Urban centres also developed outside this core.
- **Jana** = people/tribal community; **janapada** = its territorial footing/settled country; **mahajanapada** = large territorial state. Loyalty increasingly attaches to territory and ruler, although kinship remains important.
- **Agriculture did not begin in the Later Vedic or Mahajanapada period**: it was much older. This period saw intensified cultivation, settlement and surplus extraction.
- Fertile alluvium, rainfall, rivers, **iron tools and weapons**, craft specialisation, commerce and organised taxation supported state formation. Iron aided expansion but was **one factor**, not an automatic or simultaneous cause everywhere.
- The **Anguttara Nikaya** lists **16 mahajanapadas**; lists in different Buddhist/Jain traditions vary. Most lie **north of the Vindhyas**; **Assaka/Asmaka on the Godavari** is the standard southern exception.



Four leading competitors: Magadha, Kosala, Vatsa and Avanti. Magadha ultimately prevails.

2. The sixteen: place–capital–association

Eastern Ganga plain

State / region	Capital / centres	Essential association
Anga—eastern Bihar, Munger/Bhagalpur region	**Champa**, near Ganga–Champa confluence	Commercial centre; maritime-trade traditions connect it with **Suvarnabhumi**. **Bimbisara defeats Brahmadatta** and annexes Anga.
Magadha—southern Bihar, Patna/Gaya region	**Rajagriha/Girivraja → Pataliputra**	Haryankas, Shishunagas, Nandas; eventual imperial core.
Kashi	**Varanasi**	Wealth and revenue; contested by Kosala and Magadha.
Kosala—eastern UP/Awadh	**Shravasti**; **Ayodhya/Saketa** and Kushavati in different traditions	**Prasenajit/Pasenadi**, Buddha's contemporary. Sarayu divides northern/southern regions. Shakyas of Kapilavastu were within Kosalan overlordship; **Lumbini = Buddha's birthplace**.
Vajji/Vrijji—north Bihar/Tirhut	**Vaishali**; Videha centre **Mithila**	Confederacy associated with **Licchhavis, Videhas, Jnatrikas** and other clans. Traditional counts vary, often eight/nine. **Mahavira—Jnatrika clan**; **Ajatashatru defeats the confederacy**.
Malla	**Kushinara and Pava**	Buddha's final meal at **Pava**; **mahaparinirvana at Kushinara**. Clan oligarchies, not one hereditary kingdom.

- **Chetaka**: Vaishali/Vajji leader in Jain tradition; associated with Trishala (Mahavira's mother) and Chellana (Bimbisara's wife). Treat detailed kinship narratives as **tradition**, not identical accounts across all texts.
- **Kosala's capital is not simply one fixed city for its entire history**; Shravasti is the key Buddha-period association.

Upper Ganga–Yamuna and central India

State / region	Capital / centres	Essential association
Vatsa/Vamsa—Yamuna region	**Kaushambi**	**Udayana**; fine cotton textiles. Kaushambi lies **on the Yamuna, southwest of Prayagraj—not at the Ganga–Yamuna confluence**.
Kuru—Delhi/western UP	**Indraprastha**; Hastinapura in older traditions	Mahabharata's Kuru setting; distinguish epic narrative from securely dated sixth-century history.
Panchala—western/central UP	North: **Ahichchhatra** near Bareilly; south: **Kampilya** near Farrukhabad	Ganga divides northern/southern sections; **Kanyakubja/Kannauj** within the broader region.
Matsya—Rajasthan, Jaipur/Alwar/Bharatpur region	**Viratanagara/Bairat**	Virata association belongs to epic tradition; do not treat him as a securely documented sixth-century founder.
Shurasena/Surasena	**Mathura, Yamuna**	**Avantiputta/Avantipura** is associated in Buddhist tradition.

State / region	Capital / centres	Essential association
Chedi/Cheti—Bundelkhand	**Shuktimati/Sotthivatinagara**	**Shishupala** is the epic association: ally of Jarasandha/Duryodhana and killed by Krishna at Yudhishthira's Rajasuya. Not a securely dated mahajanapada-period reign.
Avanti—Malwa and adjoining Narmada region	North: **Ujjayini/Ujjain**; south: **Mahishmati**	**Pradyota**; rivalry with Vatsa and Magadha. **Shishunaga annexes Avanti**.

Udayana of Vatsa ≠ Udayin of Magadha. Udayana and Vasavadatta (Pradyota's daughter) feature in later literature: **Bhasa—Svapnavasavadatta; Harsha—Priyadarshika and Ratnavali**. These are later dramatic treatments, not contemporary political records. Kaushambi district's archaeological history.

Northwest and southern exception

State / region	Capital / centres	Essential association
Gandhara—Peshawar/Rawalpindi–Taxila region	**Takshashila/Taxila**	Trade and learning; **Pukkusati/Pushkarasarin**, associated with friendly contact with Bimbisara and rivalry with Avanti. Persian inscriptions attest **Gandara**.
Kamboja—northwestern frontier	Often **Rajapura** in standard identifications; supplied table gives **Pooncha/Poonch**	Exact boundaries/capital identifications are debated. **Horses, horsemen, Uttarapatha** are the secure recall links; do not memorise a disputed modern location as certain.
Assaka/Asmaka—Godavari region	**Potana/Potali**, often identified with **Bodhan, Telangana**	**South of Vindhyas**, Dakshinapatha; Godavari–Manjira region. Not the northwestern **Assakenoi/Ashvakas** fought by Alexander.

Map recall: northwest—Gandhara/Kamboja; upper plain—Kuru/Panchala; west—Matsya/Shurasena; central—Avanti/Chedi/Vatsa; east—Kosala/Kashi/Malla/Vajji/Magadha/Anga; south—Assaka.

3. Gana-sanghas versus monarchies

Aspect	Gana-sangha / oligarchy	Monarchy
Authority	Council/assembly of leading clan members, often collectively called **rajas**; chief **ganapati/ganaraja**	King and hereditary dynasty; ministers/advisory council
Participation	Restricted to **aristocratic ruling lineages**, usually Kshatriya men	Concentrated in king/ruling family; assemblies lose influence
Examples	**Vajji, Malla; Shakyas** as a smaller clan polity	**Magadha, Kosala, Vatsa, Avanti**
Organisation	One clan or federation; retained strong corporate/kinship structures	Larger territorial administration, taxes and professional army
Social setting	Ruling **rajakula** versus dependent labouring groups in textbook description; not an exhaustive census	Varna hierarchy and Brahmanical kingship ideals more prominent, alongside local variation

- **Santhagara** = assembly hall; **gana-puraka** = quorum-related function; **salaka** = voting token; **salaka-gahapaka** = vote collector. Textual descriptions of deliberation, unanimity and voting illustrate corporate procedure; do not assume identical rules in every polity.
- **Oligarchy ≠ modern universal democracy**. The leading lineages could be hereditary even when the chief was selected; “no hereditary element at all” is misleading.
- Many eastern ganas were near the Himalayan foothills; major kingdoms controlled fertile alluvial tracts. This is a tendency, not an absolute geographical rule.
- Less reliance on Brahmanical royal ritual offered space for heterodox thought. **Buddha—Shakya; Mahavira—Jnatrika/Vajji**. Both also preached in and received support from **monarchies**; tolerance was not exclusive to ganas.

4. Magadha: rulers and expansion

Sequence: Haryanka → Shishunaga → Nanda → Maurya. Pre-Mauryan reign dates differ between chronologies; the following are **conventional approximate teaching dates**.

Haryankas

Ruler	Recall
Bimbisara, c.544–492 BCE	Major consolidator of Magadha; **Rajagriha** capital; contemporary of Buddha/Mahavira. **Conquest + marriage + diplomacy**.
Ajatashatru, c.492–460 BCE	Bimbisara's son; accession linked with parricide in traditions. Wars over Kashi/Kosala and against Vajji; strengthens Magadha.
Udayin/Udayabhadra, c.460–444 BCE	Associated with shifting the capital to **Pataliputra**, near the ancient Ganga–Son junction; later Haryanka successors precede Shishunaga.

Bimbisara:

- **Seniya/Sreniya** epithet; associated with a standing army. Avoid claiming he was the first person anywhere to maintain one.
- Annexed **Anga**, defeating **Brahmadatta**: Champa's trade/revenue strengthened Magadha.
- Matrimonial links: **Kosalan princess**, sister of Prasenajit, associated with **Kashi's revenue as dowry**; **Chellana**, Licchhavi princess; **Madra princess** from Punjab. Details of Ajatashatru's maternal genealogy vary by tradition.
- Friendship with **Pradyota** of Avanti: royal physician **Jivaka** sent to treat his jaundice at Ujjain; Pukkusati of Gandhara associated with diplomatic exchange.
- Mahavamsa account of anointment by his father means **Bimbisara need not be the literal first Haryanka**. The source's conjectural grandfather/foundation date should not be treated as established.

Ajatashatru:

- Conflict with **Prasenajit** over Kashi ends with Magadha retaining it in narrative accounts. **Do not equate this automatically with a secure conquest of all Kosala in his reign**.
- Defeated **Vajji/Licchhavis**; traditions describe a prolonged war and minister **Vassakara's diplomacy/dissension**. Sixteen years is a traditional duration, not a securely reconstructed exact campaign calendar.
- Two famous war machines in literary tradition: **mahashilakantaka—stone-thrower; rathamusala—mace/scythed chariot**.

- Fortification against Avanti; Pataligrama's strategic development is also associated with his reign. **Udayin** is remembered for the later capital shift.
- Buddha's death and **First Buddhist Council at Rajagriha** are placed in his reign by Buddhist tradition. Buddhist chronological systems differ; do not force one exact Buddha-death date into every regnal table.
- Udayin's killing at Avanti ruler **Palaka's** instigation is a traditional account, not certain established fact.

Shishunagas, c.412–345 BCE

- **Shishunaga**: traditionally an amatya/viceroy at Varanasi, elevated after discontent with Haryanka successors. **Annexation of Avanti/ending Pradyota power** is the key achievement. Associated with a temporary capital at **Vaishali**.
- **Kalashoka/Kalasoka**, linked with **Kakavarna** in Puranic tradition: capital returns to **Pataliputra**; **Second Buddhist Council at Vaishali** associated with his reign.

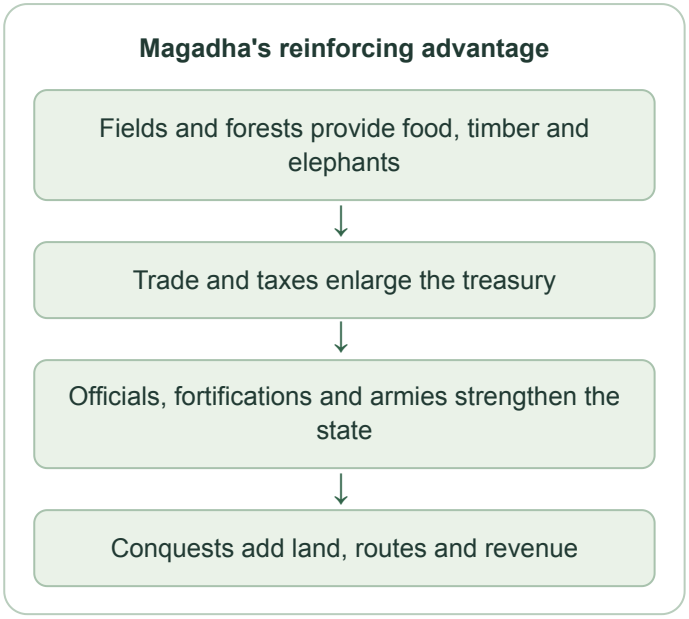
Nandas, c.345–321 BCE

- **Mahapadma Nanda**: **Ugrasena** association; titles **ekarat** (sole sovereign) and **sarva-kshatrantaka** (destroyer/uprooter of Kshatriyas). Expands Magadha, associated with **Kosala and Kalinga**, organised taxation, canals and irrigation.
- The removal of a **Jina image** and a Nanda-era canal in Kalinga are known through later traditions/epigraphic recollection; do not treat every detail as a contemporary Nanda inscription.
- Brahmanical accounts depict Shudra/non-Kshatriya maternal origin; Buddhist accounts describe obscure lineage (**annatakula**). **Conflicting and sometimes hostile origin traditions are not proof of one exact caste biography**. “First non-Kshatriya dynasty” is a textbook label requiring this qualification.
- **Dhana Nanda**: last major Nanda, associated with Greek **Agrammes/Xandrames**; enormous army and heavy taxation in literary accounts. Exact army numbers and character judgements need source criticism.
- **Nandopakramani**: a measure associated with Nanda tradition; avoid assigning a securely documented personal invention to Dhana Nanda.
- Alexander reached Punjab during the late Nanda period, **never conquered Magadha and never fought Dhana Nanda**. Reports of eastern military strength may have contributed to his army's reluctance, alongside exhaustion.
- **Chandragupta Maurya**, traditionally assisted by **Kautilya/Chanakya**, overthrows the Nandas and establishes Mauryan rule **c.321 BCE** (dates vary slightly).

5. Why Magadha succeeded

Advantage	Political consequence
Fertile, well-watered middle Ganga alluvium, rice cultivation	Agricultural surplus → revenue → standing army
Access to iron-producing areas of southern Bihar/Chhotanagpur and surrounding regions	Tools and arms; access/control developed over time, not proof of an exclusive iron monopoly
Forests: timber and elephants	Construction and military resources; large-scale elephant warfare
Rajagriha: hills/stone defences	Naturally defensible early capital
Pataliputra: river junctions and routes	Communication, commerce and defence; ancient river courses differed from today's

Advantage	Political consequence
River trade, Champa and expanding towns/coinage	Tolls/customs and commercial wealth
Ambitious rulers, marriages, diplomacy, conquest	Resources converted into durable territorial expansion



Explanation: geography provided opportunities; political choices mobilised them. Magadha's varied religious/social environment may have helped new institutions, but “unorthodox people were inherently more expansionist” is not a sufficient causal claim. NCERT: early states and economies.

6. Persian expansion in the northwest

- Political fragmentation in the northwest facilitated **Achaemenid expansion**. **Cyrus** operated on the eastern frontier in the sixth century BCE; detailed claims about his conquests of particular Indian localities remain uncertain. His reign is usually dated **c.559–530 BCE**, not the source's 558–529 as an unquestionable standard.
- **Darius I** extended/consolidated control over parts of the **Indus region**, conventionally dated **c.518 BCE**. **Gandara and Hindush** appear in Persian imperial geography; exact territorial limits and the timing of incorporation require care.
- **Herodotus: Gandarians belong to tribute district VII**, with other groups; **Indians to district XX**, credited with **360 talents of gold dust**. **Gandhara itself was not the twentieth district.** These tribute districts should not be treated as a perfectly interchangeable map of all administrative satrapies. Herodotus, tribute list.
- Indian/Gandarian contingents served in Persian armies, including **Xerxes' fifth-century BCE campaigns against Greece**. Achaemenid–northwestern contacts lasted roughly two centuries before Alexander; control was neither all-India nor necessarily uniform throughout.

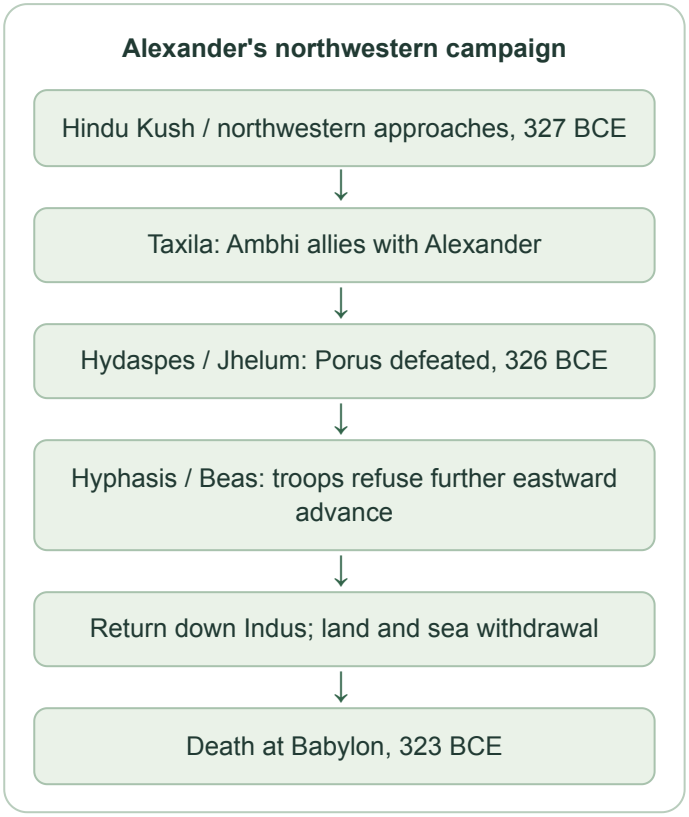
Persian connections to remember

Field	Association and limit
Script	**Kharoshthi**, derived from **Aramaic**, generally **right to left**; Ashokan use in the northwest. **Not alternate-direction/boustrophedon writing**.

Field	Association and limit
Coinage	Persian **sigloi** and regional adaptations; not proof that every Indian coin originated as a Persian copy.
Royal display	Possible Persian influence on Mauryan inscriptional conventions, monumental art and **bell-shaped pillar capitals**. Capitals belong to **pillars**, not to “rock edicts”.
Exchange	Trade, administrative contacts and artistic interaction; Indian traditions adapted outside influences rather than merely reproducing Persian culture.

7. Alexander: campaign, limit and effects

Alexander III, 356–323 BCE, son of **Philip II of Macedon**. Defeated **Darius III** and the Achaemenid Empire before campaigning in the northwest **327–325 BCE**; the key Punjab battle is **326 BCE**.



- **Ambhi = Taxila; Porus = kingdom east of the Jhelum**, not Taxila. Porus was restored as a subordinate ruler after defeat.
- Porus was **not the only resisting opponent**: northwestern hill communities and later **Malloi/Malavas** also fought. Alexander was seriously wounded during the latter resistance.
- **Beas/Hyphasis** = eastern limit; army exhaustion, casualties, homesickness and fear of further campaigning matter. Twelve altars traditionally marked the limit. **No Ganga crossing, Magadha conquest or Nanda battle**.
- **Nearchus** led the fleet from the Indus towards the Persian Gulf; Alexander returned partly by the difficult **Gedrosian land route**. The source's “19 months” is a conventional campaign-duration reckoning; dates depend on the geographical boundaries used.
- Died in **Babylon, 323 BCE—not 326**. Rule involved satraps and subordinate local rulers. **Seleucus was not simply appointed governor of all northwestern India during Alexander's retreat**; his later eastern claims belong to the post-Alexander successor struggles. British Museum: Alexander's final years.

Consequences, without exaggeration

- **Political:** disruption of small northwestern powers and temporary Macedonian garrisons; later Mauryan consolidation exploited a changing situation. Alexander did not himself unify India or make Mauryan success inevitable.
- **Knowledge:** campaign narratives supply geographical, social and chronological evidence; later writers preserve many lost eyewitness reports. Read claims about sati, sale of daughters and cattle **critically**, not as practices proved universal across India. Large cattle-export numbers are literary claims.
- **Trade/contact:** strengthened land and sea links between northwest India and the Hellenistic world; Nearchus' voyage is important. Contacts with Greeks existed through Persia earlier, so this was not the first conceivable India–Europe contact.
- **Art:** Hellenistic traditions contributed to later **Gandharan art** through centuries of interaction. **The mature Buddhist Gandhara school was not founded instantly by Alexander in 326 BCE.** Metropolitan Museum: Gandhara's long artistic development.

8. Material culture, villages and towns

NBPW and coinage

- **NBPW = Northern Black Polished Ware**: fine, wheel-made, well-fired luxury/table pottery with a distinctive lustrous surface; strongly associated with the early historic Ganga valley. Its dating varies by site; do not give all first finds one exact 600 BCE date.
- The name is not an absolute description of distribution/colour: examples occur beyond the north, including **Amaravati**; shades vary. Usually unpainted, with occasional painted designs—waves, circles, bands and dots.
- **PGW precedes/overlaps NBPW in some regional sequences**, not one uniform all-India replacement. **Atranjikhera, Etah, UP** helps trace changing settlement/material life.
- Early **punch-marked coins**: predominantly **silver**, some copper; separate symbols punched onto metal—hill, tree, bull, fish, crescent, elephant. **Punch-marked ≠ machine-minted portrait coinage**.
- Money supported prices, wages and exchange. **Nishka and shatamana** had earlier weight/value associations; do not assume every Vedic nishka was a struck coin. **Panini's Ashtadhyayi: vetana—wage; vaitanika—wage earner**.
- Burnt bricks and ring wells become significant in later parts of the NBPW/early historic sequence; **burnt brick itself was known much earlier in Harappan cities**.
- Writing could facilitate accounts and revenue administration, but **a universal written bureaucracy in 600 BCE is not established**; securely dated Ashokan inscriptions belong to the third century BCE.

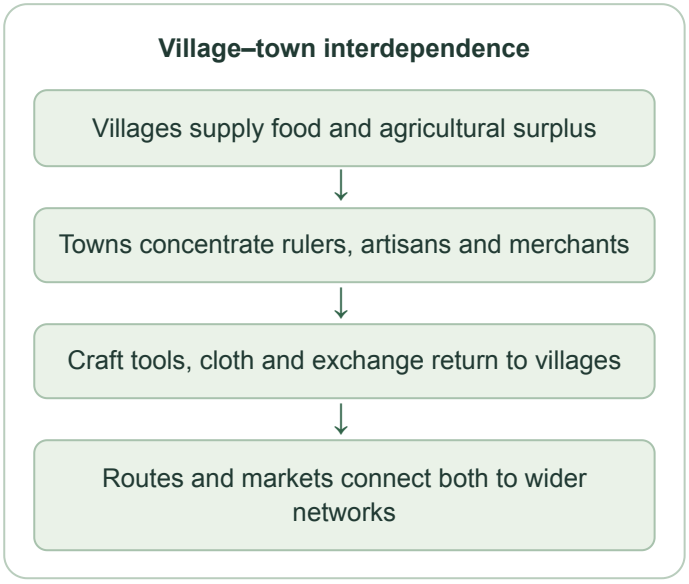
Settlement vocabulary

Term	Recall
Grama	Village
Nigama	Market settlement, intermediate between village and larger town
Pura / nagara	Town/city, often fortified in context
Nagaraka	Smaller town in the chapter's terminology
Mahanagara	Major city
Rajadhani	Capital

Major centres: **Varanasi, Kaushambi, Rajagriha, Pataliputra, Shravasti, Ayodhya, Vaishali, Champa and Kapilavastu**. Their scale and growth dates differed; “all were equally large cities already in 600 BCE” is incorrect.

Rural economy and urban dependence

- **Rice** central in the middle Ganga plain; **paddy transplantation**, iron ploughshares and alluvial fertility aided output. Also barley, pulses, millets, cotton and sugarcane. Rice predominance here does not mean one staple throughout the subcontinent.
- Family cultivation, unequal holdings, hired labour and **dasa-kammakara** (enslaved/dependent workers and labourers) coexist. **Gahapati** = substantial household/property holder, often a wealthy cultivator; not every occurrence means the same landlord category.
- Typical villages headed by **gramabhojaka/gramini/gramaka**: revenue links and local order. Craft villages include **vaddhaki—carpenters; nalakara—reed workers; lonakara—salt workers; chariot makers**. Frontier villages linked farms with forest-based hunting/gathering economies.
- The supplied text calls frontier villages *aramika-grama*; **aramika also denotes attendants/monastic workers in Pali**, so do not treat that term as a universal precise synonym for a border village.
- Irrigation channels could be collective; village headmen coordinated work. Textual references to gifts/sales show changing property relations, **not the sudden first invention of private property**.
- Agricultural dues often expressed as **bhaga**, conventionally **one-sixth**; rates varied. **Bali** develops from offering/tribute towards more compulsory exaction; the two terms should not automatically be identical everywhere.
- Grants to Brahmanas/merchants occur in narratives. Their revenue or administrative rights depended on the grant and period; **do not project the full later land-grant system backwards**.



9. Crafts, commerce and routes

- Specialised **textiles, pottery, ivory working** and other crafts; occupations often transmitted within families. Artisans/merchants gathered in occupational quarters; **vessas** = merchant streets/localities in the chapter's terminology.
- **Shreni/guild**: coordination of production, standards, prices, training and member welfare; internal dispute settlement/protection in some accounts. **Fully developed judicial or military powers should not be assigned to every guild already in the sixth century BCE**.
- **Setthi/shreshthin** = wealthy merchant/banker; trade and lending. **Gahapati** and **setthi** may overlap in wealth but are not identical offices.

- **Uttarapatha**: northwest/Taxila across the northern plains towards eastern centres and **Tamralipti**. **Dakshinapatha**: routes from northern centres through **central India/Avanti to Pratishthana/Paithan on the Godavari**, with western coastal links. These are **networks**, not two unchanging modern highways laid out at once.
- External connections: Taxila–Afghanistan–Iran–Mesopotamia; Bengal towards Myanmar/Southeast Asia; river and sea travel. Different links are attested in texts of different dates—avoid dating the entire later network to 600 BCE.
- Trade included precious metals (**gold/silver—not "precious stones"**), stones such as lapis lazuli/jade, textiles, ivory, pottery, sandalwood and pearls. Imports/exports varied by region; no rigid one-way all-India list.

10. Administration, law and society

Officials and extraction

Term	Function / recall
Amatya / mahamatra	Higher official; executive, judicial, fiscal or military responsibilities depending on context
Mantrin	Minister
Senanayaka	Army commander—**not the standard tax collector**
Ayukta	Appointed official / subordinate administrative function
Balisadhaka	Collector of bali
Kamika; shaulkika / shulkadhyaksha	Customs/toll-related officials in textual descriptions
Rajabhata	Royal personnel; protection/enforcement functions in the chapter
Vassakara	Magadhan minister associated with Ajatashatru's Vajji policy

- Larger armies required revenue, officials and labour: agricultural dues, merchandise tolls and compulsory work for royal purposes. **Sabha/samiti decline in monarchical political importance; parishad/council advises the king**.
- Brahmanas supplied influential advisers; do not assume **every council everywhere consisted exclusively of Brahmanas**, or that all kingdoms had one identical bureaucracy.

Varna, kinship and gender

- Brahmanical ideal: **Brahmana—ritual/teaching; Kshatriya—rule/war; Vaishya—production/taxation; Shudra—service**. **Dvija** refers to the first three in normative ritual classification.
- Prescriptive texts impose unequal ritual/legal rights and varna-dependent penalties, with marked Shudra disabilities. **Normative hierarchy ≠ every person's actual occupation/status**; not all cultivators were Vaishyas or all Shudras slaves.
- King's agents administered justice alongside local/customary norms. This was **not the first appearance of law or dispute resolution in India**, and all criminal law cannot be reduced to "eye for an eye".
- **Nati/nati-kulani**: wider kin groups; **kula**: family, often patrilineal context; **nataka**: relatives on both maternal/paternal sides. Kinship retained influence even within renunciant communities.
- Patrilineal inheritance and caste endogamy reinforced controls on marriage and women's sexuality; son preference linked with lineage/funerary rites. Buddhist/Jain/Brahmanical texts preserve patriarchal expectations, alongside women exercising religious/economic agency.

- **Samyutta Nikaya** narrative: Buddha consoles **Prasenajit** at a daughter's birth, affirming that a daughter may surpass a son, though the passage still uses conventional wife/mother roles.
- Religious life included Brahmanical sacrifice, local/tree/animal-associated cults and **shramana movements**. Universal statements—“all followed Brahmanism”, “all Shudras exploited by everyone”, “all women entirely free”—misrepresent diversity.

11. PYQ and answer-writing recall

UPSC Mains 2023, GS I: “Explain the role of geographical factors towards the development of Ancient India.”

Answer structure:

1. **Physical setting:** Himalayas and passes shaped protection/contact; rivers and monsoon shaped cultivation and settlement.

2. **Resources:** alluvium, forests, metals and animals supported agriculture, crafts and warfare—use **Magadha** as the main example.

3. **Communication:** navigable rivers, land corridors and coasts enabled exchange; **Taxila, Champa, Kaushambi, Pataliputra** illustrate strategic locations.

4. **Regional diversity:** Harappan plains, Ganga basin, plateau and coastal environments supported different trajectories; geography also produced floods, barriers and uneven connectivity.

5. **Judgement:** geography supplied opportunities/constraints; technology, institutions and human decisions determined their use. Avoid geographical determinism.

Practice-key traps to correct

- **Bimbisara ≠ Bindusara**: Haryanka consolidator versus later Mauryan ruler. **Udayana ≠ Udayin**: Vatsa dramatical hero versus Magadhan capital shift.
- **Rajagriha = hill-defended; Pataliputra = river-defended.** Kaushambi is on **Yamuna**, not at Prayagraj's confluence.
- **Kharoshthi = right to left**; alternating directions is not its normal rule.
- **Gandhara = Herodotus' VII, Indian tribute district = XX**: the supplied practice answer calling Gandhara XX is incorrect.
- **Porus ≠ Taxila's Ambhi**; Alexander **did not conquer Magadha**; **323 BCE** is his death year.
- The source's broad claims about sati/sale of girls do not establish universal prevalence. Its practice question on religious/social life is too sweeping for an unqualified “all” answer.
- Grain surplus, trade and state power reinforced one another; no single cause explains second urbanisation. **Undated textbook practice exercises are not official UPSC PYQs**.

Last-minute chain: 16 states → four major rivals → Magadha; Haryanka → Shishunaga → Nanda → Maurya; Rajagriha → Pataliputra; Assaka → Godavari; Vajji/Malla → oligarchies; NBPW → towns/coinage; Hydaspes → Jhelum, Hyphasis → Beas.